



This article, which features chefs, recipes and knives, isn't about cooking in the kitchen. It heralds a new series of articles in the Dev-ops corner. Subsequent articles in the series will explain how to configure Chef agents in workstation nodes and how to link the agents to the Chef server. We will also cook some recipes for Chef configuration.

Software product development consists of a series of planned activities. During the SDLC (software development life cycle) phase of program development, repetitive actions are required for design refinement, review fixes, build, deployment and regression testing. With the advent of newer programming methodologies and modes of execution like agile and extreme programming, there is a need to automate such tasks to a greater extent.

When we automate various stages in the SDLC cycle, depending on the methodology we adopt for the project or the time line for execution, there is a greater demand for the repeated actions of build, deployment, unit testing and promoting the build to the next stage. These activities occur at multiple stages (development, integration testing, system testing, user acceptance and load testing) and repeatedly (for various phases of releases). Saving the time spent in such

complex and repetitive tasks helps in improving productivity and reducing manual failures.

So, there is a definite need for automating repeated tasks in build preparation, build and packaging, deployment and in unit/regression testing. This process is called continuous delivery. Continuous delivery is the process of automating the build/release process in the life cycle of software configuration and delivery. It differs from regular build/deployment in that it is a process of automatic delivery with less manual intervention and runs automatically during code check-ins.

Chef is a popular automation platform for this process of continuous delivery, as it considers infrastructure as a code and helps in build/deployment regularly; it also integrates automatic regression testing to enable certification of the build for promotion to the next stage. Chef helps the software configuration manager to programmatically handle build, deploy,